

The Obsequies of the Gods

An approach to humanistic religion

"In the name of God, I can do everything? In the name of man, I can do nothing?"

Modern man is a forlorn clown amidst his spurious mosaic of existence: his action is powerless, his mind dissociates from reality, his life is paved with abysmal loneliness, his agonized countenance ghastly delineates his apathy and impotence in relation to the objective world. To seek any consistent image of him will surely be futile and discouraging - his portrait is but a nihilistic one. The plurality of conflicting modern ideologies has compelled man to forsake his well-scrubbed cradle of traditional, authoritarian religions, leaving him in a creations state of indecisive anxiety. Ethical relativism has parched his touchstone of reality to another Hiroshima. Gone are the Gods and the myths man clings to. Gone are the *ius divinum* and dogmatism man entertains. Grasped in the infinite, ever-expanding spiral of metamorphoses, he traipses like a lost child inside his labyrinthine superstructure. Only darkness and despair prevail; not even a trace of edifying light can be found. But to weep or linger in such appalling night is of no avail - for it can only throttle his² hope slowly, aggravate his fright and anxiety and nothing else. After all, is it better still, and prouder indeed, to be a bold explorer than a mere marionette of the times? Really, modern man is adrift on the raft of the Medusa in the seething ocean of meaninglessness; he is just a

rover craving for a spiritual home but is denied it. The grasp of the complexity of his social institutions and his objective reality renders him powerless, creating crimes, social evils and a general disgust of life. This is a society of voluptuary, draped with braided ditches and good food. This is also a world of misery, beset by wars, crimes and pollutions. Thus, to man, any objective, absolute value system is but a delusion; any frantic, zealous belief is but a myth. And delusion does not exist; myth dies as well. Instead of the Gross or the Communist Manifesto, the sign of modern man is absurdity and absurdity is the very being of his world, the very stuff of his reality. Perhaps nothing can be more distressing and preposterous for him - a wanderer who realizes that the only truth in the world is that he shall never find what he is for. Consequently, his actions become powerless, frozen. His existence becomes isolated - there is nothing left for man except an incongruous suffocating spiritual vacuum. All he can do is to jump into the fathomless vortex of mass culture, carried away by its ordeal and homogenized by its appeal. Only numbness and anxiety dominate his life. Only Thanatos triumphs and rejoices in its relentless grin.

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at all, man must henceforth build a shrine for his ideals and create a humanistic religion for himself. Suppose that man is but a fortuitous conglomeration of atoms, a lonesome child of probability in the course of evolution with no prevision of what he is and what he shall be. Or that he is a son of the star-dusts without cause or *jus divinum* of any kind; that the zenith of man's strivings, his arts, his sciences, his ideals, his music will inevitably be buried in the debris of the expanding universe; and that his consciousness, his soul, his loves and hopes, his gods and his beliefs will never survive after his brief years of life. Or suppose that time is irreversible and that the whole universe is running down with increasing entropy, by which no devout prayers, no heroism, no passionate longings, no lofty aspirations can reverse or even hope to preserve; and that any value system is arbitrary and that truth is merely the *crude* of the gods, determined solely by the vogue of the ages. Or even that all the splendour of human achievements, all the loftiest emotions, all the aspects of humanity, are destined to vanish in the dusk ad infinitum. Yet, these generalizations and prognostications, if not absolutely certain, are not far from the truth - that any religion or philosophy whatsoever, in their ephemeral course of existence, should endorse, or else be fallen.

The Fall of man - the obsequies of the gods

Man is not man before Adam and Eve - he was enthralled to his physical universe, under the mercy of the inexorable powers of Nature. For epochs, he was a creature of instinctual patterns, conditioned by his natural environment. He fed, walked, killed and reproduced without cause, and without asking a cause. He was just an unthinking animal, manipulated by the gods. Yet, however improbable, a miracle occurred - the omnipotent but blind Nature in her secular epopee through the abysses of space, had at last brought forth a child called man, still under her dominion, but gifted with self-awareness, with knowledge of good and evil, and with an objective system of studying the handiwork of his alien and inhuman Mother. Thus, the first fall of man began - he ceased to be the mere puppets of his Lords. Despite the fact that he was tempted to lead a settled life, to practise a powerful discipline called science and to transcend his natural universe, he was still, at times, tyrannized by his physical reality. Fearful and timid as he was, and as he is, he seeks compassions from the gods - which are but the higher phase of his consciousness. Moreover, knowing that he can't never taste the forbidden fruit of immortality, he invents systems of theology to fulfil his vain reverie, so that after his irrevocable death, he can't still inherit eternal life - to be as his gods. Haunted in his ultimate concern,

the savage man can do nothing but impose his own beliefs on others, as a system of ultimate, indubitable truth. Disobedience and infidelity¹⁰ are regarded as the gravest sins and are supposed to deserve everlasting damnation. Thus, in the name of his Gods, the savage man can do everything. Such also is the attitude of those, who, in our age, base their belief upon any kind of dogmatic ideologies and the like.

The birth pangs of modern agnosticism and humanism have temporarily caused man to lose his self-identity and his consciousness. But all these perverse and unwholesome phenomena, as called by the priests, are but the mere inception of their long-repressed nightmare - the upheaval of iconoclastic Evolutionism and Freudism has already shattered their autistic reveries of anthropocentrism and piety; Victorian Puritanism has undergone a bizarre dialectical reversal and re-emerges as Dionysian orgies; radical atheism blooms brilliantly from the bud of devout religiosity by which the Gods are guillotined. Thus springs the second fall of man - the degeneration of man from an instinctual, helpless and emotionally morbid creature to an autonomous, independent and thinking being, has paid homage to the obsequies of the Gods. Man is no creature any more. He is the creator, the creator of his own Fate, his own being and destiny. Man no longer conforms to the immutable necessity of determinism¹² - once again, he is bestowed the Edenic apple of freedom. Nevertheless, his acquired

free will forces him to renounce his ultimate source of security - his refuge in authoritarian religions. There is nothing, absolutely nothing in this world to guide him; he has to face his world alone; he has to cope with his nostalgia and loneliness inherent in his extraterrestrial life. In his godless world everything is possible. In his chaotic universe, every entity is a reductio ad absurdum.

The death of the gods - the birth of humanity.

The answer to our age is not blowing in the wind; nor does it lie in any sacred doctrinaire books with inviolable, deterministic truth. The answer to our age lies in ourselves. By actively transcending ourselves, we can erect a humanistic religion, a shrine where man can ennoble his little days. It is time for man to wear from the lethal ambrosia of dogmatism. It is time for man to liberate himself from the tyranny of the gods. It is time for man to murder his gods in his hearts. To defy the gods with fierce hatred to will the death of the gods, seem necessary and inevitable to the assertion of freedom. The free man can do nothing but admit that the gods are but his devils; for he, by his very own nature, is a sempiternal rover, an agnostic wanderer with humanity at heart and indeterminism in mind.

What move me as a human being, an individual of the species *Homo sapiens*, are not the facets and tragedies of my experience, but the similitude of my experience with others. Upon this cornerstone of empathy, upon this concrete humanity, we can penetrate and consolidate with the emotional being of our fellow men; we can transform the vision of our mundane world into a celestial paradise. No longer do we demand that we are infallible and perfect. However, we can accept and transcend our flaw and blemish with the courage to be, without losing our starry hopes and lofty aspirations. We sometimes are enshrouded by despair and woe, agonized by the omnipotent Fate. Many times have we faltered. Many times have we been thwarted and languished by our loss and defeat, under the bondage of Self. Many times have we been veiled by our improvident outlook. Brooded by our morbid thoughts, our hopes become diminished. Our senses become inebriated. Our world seems to be ¹⁵sombre and desperate. Yet, as our insight into life grows, we realize that life itself is too transient to be obsessed by personal joy or grief. We realize that we have to give; we have to inquire into the external world and transcend it; we have to discern people, to feel with them without any intellectual pride; we have to develop a never-tiring joy of learning and giving. Let us recall that our fellow-men are but ourselves. Brief their lives are, their bliss or misery depend on us. In this absurd world of being, where are

are condemned to ¹⁷love our dearest, where death triumphs in its universal roar, there is nothing left except to cherish and to give. Reality, to us, is always novel and capricious; yet we can always achieve ontological security through the tenderness of human love, the humility of independence and the merging of our sciences and humanities. Acceptance, tolerance and transcendence are our virtues. Mystical love can transform our selves completely the exaltation of our beloved, allied with the acceptance and transcendence of the defects of humanity, can cause an existential re incarnation in our selves. The experience of other selves is always new, refreshing ¹⁸and is with exploration, love and exaltation. This gives us not only a unity with our fellow men, but also a cosmic consciousness and an existential rebirth which are but our ultimate concern, which we and the Universe exist in the highest consummation. We immediately feel that we, the human race are but One. The free man recognizes no dogma but the dogma of affection. He senses no obstacle but the obstacle of ligotys. In order to perceive our complex, intricate world and to change it, it is necessary for us to shake off our intellectual and moral pride, to feel with the mass, yet to stand aloof analytically; to share others' experience, joy and sadness, yet to be aware of the objective conditions.

Be it ours to shed light upon them, to be empathic with their life. In a universe where entropy always increases, where universal death is inevitable, we can do nothing but to accept it. Through our endeavours, I believe that we can be tragically beautiful and make our fleeting existence unique, as well as eternal. Let us blaze with the fervent zest of life. We falter but we strive to stand. We suffer rejection but continue to give. Let us not judge people by our grudging scale of merits or demerits, but rather let us think in their own terms and extend our precious quality of empathy. In this way, we can become deeply religious, thus giving us a feeling of pantheistic ecstasy and individualized religiosity. In this way, and perhaps no other, we can be the true children of the Universe.

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